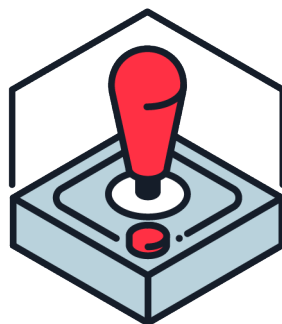




Video Game Metadata Schema: Controlled Vocabulary for THEME

University of Washington Information School
Game Research (GAMER) Group and
Seattle Interactive Media Museum



GAMER
GAME RESEARCH GROUP

Release 1.2
2024-12-12

Research Team

Main Contributors

Jin Ha Lee, Ph.D. (jinhalee@uw.edu)
Andrew Perti (Seattle Interactive Media Museum)
Vikram Thirumalai (University of Washington)
Heather Welch (University of Washington)
Andrea Zachary (University of Washington)
Tamanh Nguyen (University of Washington)

Suggested Citation

Please cite this document as follows:

Lee, J. H., Perti, A., Thirumalai, V., Welch, H., Zachary, A., & Nguyen, T. (2024). *UW/SIMM Video Game Metadata Schema: Controlled Vocabulary for Theme*. Version 1.2. Retrieved from: http://gamer.ischool.uw.edu/official_release/

Version History

1.0: June 2015, Initial release

1.2: September 2024

1.2: December 2024, Formatting update: Updated reference structure for improved visual clarity and ease of use, with no changes to content. Table formatting was removed, and relationships between terms are now displayed hierarchically through indentation, with narrower terms shown as subsets of broader terms. Included relevant term relationships (SN, USE, USE FOR, BT, NT, RT) as appropriate.

Abbreviation Key

The following abbreviations are used throughout:

SN: Scope note
USE: Preferred term (See)
USE FOR: Equivalent term, lead-in term
BT: Broader term
NT: Narrower term
RT: Related term (See also)

Controlled Vocabulary for Theme

Abandonment

USE: **Alienation**

Alienation

SN: The state or experience of being isolated from a group or an activity to which one should belong or in which one should be involved

USE FOR: **Abandonment, Isolation**

Examples: *Dead Space, Ecco the Dolphin*

Abduction

SN: The state or experience of one's life being threatened after forcefully being taken away against one's will

Adult

SN: Dealing in or with explicit sexual material

Alter-egos

SN: A second self, which is believed to be distinct from a person's normal or original personality, often used as a disguise

RT: **Identity**

Examples: *Muramasa, Prince of Persia: The 2 Thrones*

Anti-war

SN: The mentality used to describe activists who are opposed to war

RT: **War**

Apocalypse

SN: The end of a world, in which inhabitants of the world are in total disarray over the destruction of their home

USE FOR: **Post Apocalypse**

Autobiography

USE: **Biography**

Betrayal

SN: The breaking or violation of an explicit or presumptive contract, trust, or confidence that produces moral and psychological conflict within a relationship amongst individuals, between organizations, or between individuals and organizations

Examples: *Asura's Wrath, Fable*

Biography

SN: The story of one's life, as told through the perspectives of someone else

USE FOR: **Autobiography**

Bisexuality

USE: **LGBT**

Capitalism

SN: An economic and political system in which a country's trade and industry are controlled by private owners for profit, rather than by the state

RT: **Politics, Wealth, Work**

Examples: *Tropico*, *Capitalism (series)*, *Railroad Tycoon*

Civilization

SN: The process by which a society or place reaches various stages of social development and organization beyond hunter-gatherer society

USE FOR: **Creation**

RT: **Conquest**

Examples: *Farmville*, *Civilization*, *Spore*

Combat

USE: **Violence**

Coming-of-age

USE: **Growth**

Companionship

SN: A feeling of fellowship or friendship

USE FOR: **Family, Friendship, Loyalty**

RT: **Love**

Examples: *Nintendogs*

Competition

SN: The act or process of trying to get or win something (such as a prize or a higher level of success) that someone else is also trying to get or win; the act or process of competing

Examples: *Burnout Paradise*, *MarioKart*

Conquest

SN: The act of gaining control of (a problem or difficulty) through great effort

RT: **Civilization**

Examples: *Command & Conquer*, *Pokémon Conquest*

Conservation

SN: The act of maintaining and bettering the world by caring for the environment; this includes reducing waste, reusing or recycling materials, and looking out for animal habitats

Conspiracy

SN: Of or relating to the belief that an event was orchestrated by a powerful group of people in secret

Corruption

SN: Impairment of integrity, virtue, or moral principle, especially of those in power

USE FOR: **Greed, Innocence**

Examples: *Mafia II*

Creation

USE: **Civilization**

Crime

SN: Actions that are deemed injurious to the public welfare or to the interests of the state and that are legally prohibited

NT: **Heist**

Examples: *Grand Theft Auto*, *Sleeping Dogs*

Heist

SN: An organized crime where criminals have a sophisticated plan to steal valuable items e.g., money, jewelry, or famous works of art

BT: **Crime**

Curse

USE: **Occult**

Death

SN: Relating to the loss of a life, and the ability of those around them to cope with never seeing them again

Destruction

SN: The widespread damage of a particular place or thing

Diplomacy

SN: Relating to peaceful negotiations with other parties

Duty

USE: **Honor**

Dystopia

SN: A society in which social or technological trends have culminated in a greatly diminished quality of life or degradation of values

Examples: *BioShock*, *Crysis 3*

Economy

SN: The process or system by which goods and services are produced, sold, and bought in a country or region

Education

SN: The formal field that dictates how obtaining institutionalized knowledge is passed down from generation to generation

Espionage

SN: Relating to acts of spying, often between different countries

USE FOR: **Spy**

Evolution

SN: The process by which living things have adapted to changes in their surroundings over time, often by altering their genetic makeup

Faith

SN: Something that is believed with strong conviction

USE FOR: **Religion**

Examples: *El Shaddai*

Family

USE: **Companionship**

Fate

SN: The development of events beyond a person's control, regarded as determined by a supernatural power

RT: **Prophecy**

Examples: *Threads of Fate*

Financial gain

USE: **Wealth**

Forgiveness

USE: **Redemption**

Freedom

SN: The power or right to act, speak, or think as one wants without hindrance or restraint.

Examples: *Enslaved: Odyssey to the West*

Friendship

USE: **Companionship**

Gay

USE: **LGBT**

Greed

USE: **Corruption**

Growth

SN: The attainment of prominence, respectability, recognition, or maturity; usually a young person's transition from childhood to adulthood

USE FOR: **Coming-of-age, Maturity**

Examples: *Fable, The Last of Us*

Holiday

SN: The celebration of an event that is common between a large group of people, e.g., Christmas, Thanksgiving, etc.

Honor

SN: Respect that is given to someone who is admired; good reputation; good quality or character as judged by other people; high moral standards of behavior

USE FOR: **Duty, Patriotism, Reputation, Truth**

RT: **Redemption**

Examples: *Disgaea, Fallout 3*

Identity

SN: The distinguishing characteristics or personality of an individual

USE FOR: **Individual versus society**

RT: **Alter-egos**

Examples: *Remember Me*

Illuminati

SN: The secret organization/society dedicated to the opposition of religious influences over the public, as well as the abuse of state power

Individual versus society

USE: **Identity**

Injustice

USE: **Justice**

Innocence

USE: **Corruption**

Isolation

USE: **Alienation**

Justice

SN: The quality of being just, impartial, or fair; the principle or ideal of just dealing or right action

USE FOR: **Injustice**

Examples: *Phoenix Wright*

Knowledge

SN: Facts, information, and skills acquired from a person through experience

Examples: *Brain Age*

Lesbian

USE: **LGBT**

LGBT

SN: An initialism that stands for lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender

USE FOR: **Bisexuality, Gay, Lesbian**

Examples: *Mass Effect, Dragon Age*

Love

SN: A feeling of strong or constant affection for a person

RT: **Companionship**

USE FOR: **Romance**

Examples: *Braid, Year Walk*

Loyalty

USE: **Companionship**

Maturity

USE: **Growth**

Murder

SN: The crime in which one individual kills another in a premeditated manner

Mystery

SN: Something not understood or beyond understanding

Examples: *Eternal Darkness*

Occult

SN: Relating to the belief in the supernatural

USE FOR: **Witchcraft, Curse**

Pandemic

SN: The occurrence of a disease spreading rapidly between individuals across geographic and national boundaries

Paranormal

SN: Not understandable in terms of known scientific laws and phenomena

Patriotism

USE: **Honor**

Politics

SN: Activities that relate to influencing the actions and policies of a government or getting and keeping power in a government; a person's political thoughts and opinions

RT: **Capitalism**

Examples: *Tropico*

Power

SN: The ability or right to control people or things; political control of a country or area; a person or organization that has a lot of control and influence over other people or organizations

USE FOR: **Pride**

Examples: *BioShock: Infinite, Civilization*

Pride

USE: **Power**

Prophecy

SN: A supernatural prediction about the future

RT: **Fate**

Examples: *Odin Sphere, Year Walk*

Redemption

SN: The act of atoning for sin or wrongdoing (especially appeasing a deity)

USE FOR: **Forgiveness**

RT: **Honor**

Examples: *Dante's Inferno*

Religion

USE: **Faith**

Christianity

SN: The branch of religion that worships Christian methodologies

BT: **Religion**

Reputation

USE: **Honor**

Revenge

SN: The action of inflicting hurt or harm on someone for an injury or wrong suffered at their hands.

Examples: *Grand Theft Auto IV*

Romance

USE: **Love**

Sacrifice

SN: The selfless act in which one person gives up something of value to them for the sake of another

Savagery

USE: **Violence**

Slavery

SN: The concept in which one person is legally owned by another and forced to do their bidding without any form of reimbursement

Spy

USE: **Espionage**

Survival

SN: The state or fact of continuing to live or exist, typically in spite of an accident, ordeal, or difficult circumstances

Examples: *Canabalt*, *The Last of Us*

Technological Determinism

SN: A theory that technology determines the movement of society and its relevant social structures

Time Travel

SN: The concept in which one may move through different points in time—past or future—and experience what life is like at that moment

Truth

USE: **Honor**

Violence

SN: Behavior involving physical force intended to hurt, damage, or kill someone or something

USE FOR: **Savagery, Combat**

RT: **War**

Examples: *God of War*

War

SN: A state of armed conflict between different nations or states or different groups within a nation or state

RT: **Violence**

Examples: *Call of Duty IV*

Wealth

SN: An abundance of valuable possessions or money

USE FOR: **Financial Gain**

RT: **Capitalism, Work**

Examples: *The Patrician, Port Royale (series)*

Witchcraft

USE: **Occult**

Work

SN: Activity involving mental or physical effort done in order to achieve a purpose, result, or most often monetary gain

RT: **Capitalism, Wealth**

Examples: *The Office, Office Riot*

Types of Entities: Agent/Object

Aircraft

USE: **Vehicles**

Airforce

USE: **Military**

Airplane

SN: A fixed-wing vehicle that is used to travel the skies

USE FOR: **Aircraft**

Animals

SN: Different species of living organisms on earth that humans coexist with, excluding plants

NT: **Pets, Farm Animals**

Pets

SN: Animals that have been domesticated and can be kept in one's home, often for companionship

BT: **Animals**

Cats

SN: A (typically) four-legged animal that meows and purrs; they are usually small in size, low maintenance, and of the same family as lions, tigers, etc.

BT: **Pets**

Dogs

SN: A (typically) four-legged animal that barks and has the title of "man's best friend"

BT: **Pets**

Farm Animals

SN: Animals that have been domesticated for the use of farming; humans may also seek companionship from these animals, but they often do not live in the same shelter as humans

BT: **Animals**

Horses

SN: A large, four-legged animal that neighs and whinnies; before cars, humans often rode atop this animal with a saddle or hitched them up to a wagon

BT: **Farm Animals**

Aquatic Life

SN: Relating to any beings that predominantly live and operate underwater

USE FOR: **Fish, Whale**

Boat/Ship

SN: A vehicle that is used to travel on water

USE FOR: **Watercraft**

Car/Truck

SN: A (usually) four-wheeled vehicle that operates on gasoline

Dragons

SN: The mythical winged beast, often reptilian in appearance, that can fly and breathe fire

Fish

USE: **Aquatic Life**

Gangs

SN: A group of individuals that band together under leadership and/or similar ideals, often for the purpose of crime

NT: **Mafia, Yakuza**

RT: **Warriors**

Mafia

SN: Gangs characterized by Italian individuals and underground crime rings

BT: **Gangs**

Yakuza

SN: The Japanese form of the mafia/gangs

BT: **Gangs**

Ghosts

SN: The supernatural form of one's spirit after their passing from the mortal world

Mechs

USE: **robots**

Military

SN: A nation's army and chief defense against other nations

USE FOR: **Soldiers, Airforce, Navy**

RT: **Warriors**

Monsters

SN: An imaginary creature often depicted as scary and fiercely abnormal

Motorcycles

SN: A (usually) two-wheeled vehicle that operates on gasoline

Navy

USE: **Military**

Plants

SN: Something that grows out from soil, often starting as a seed and maturing into a different living thing like a flower

Prince

USE: **Royalty**

Princesses

USE: **Royalty**

Puppets

SN: A doll that is moved by putting your hand inside it or by pulling strings or wires that are attached to it

Robots

SN: Mechanized beings that were artificially created.

USE FOR: **Mechs**

Royalty

SN: Those who belong or marry into a royal bloodline, such as kings, queens, princes, princesses, etc.

USE FOR: **Prince, Princesses**

Submarines

SN: A vehicle that is used to travel underwater

Superheroes

SN: Extraordinary individuals with special power who dedicate their powers to fighting evil and doing good in the world; they often have powers or abilities that normal people do not (e.g., super strength, speed, flight, etc.)

Trains

SN: A mode of transportation that involves the use of railroads and railcars

Vampires

SN: an inhuman, supernatural being that often resembles humans; the chief difference is that their chief source of sustenance is blood

Warriors

SN: Individuals who fight or engage in combat

NT: **Assassin, Gladiators, Ninja, Pirates, Samurai**

RT: **Military**

Assassin

SN: Individuals who are skilled in the elimination of other people

BT: **Warriors**

RT: **Mercenary**

Gladiators

SN: Warriors from Roman times that fought in the Coliseum for sport

BT: **Warriors**

Ninja

SN: Skilled individuals, often Japanese, that fight and operate on the basis of silence and efficiency

BT: **Warriors**

Pirates

SN: Sailors who seek treasure or capture other ships

BT: **Warriors**

Samurai

SN: Noble Japanese warriors that fight in the name of honor and duty.

BT: **Warriors**

Watercraft

USE: **Boat/Ship**

Weapons

SN: items whose chief purpose is to inflict harm on others

Whale

USE: **Aquatic Life**

Wild Animals

SN: animals that have not been domesticated

Zombies

SN: The reanimated corpse of a dead person, often depicted as rotting and wanting nothing more than to eat those that are alive

Types of Entities: Activity

Building

USE: **Construction**

City-building

SN: A game focusing on the construction of a city

Combat

SN: Fighting physically or otherwise with one another

NT: **Swordplay**

Swordplay

SN: The skilled form of combat centered on the use of swords

BT: **Combat**

Construction

SN: The act or process of assembling items into a coherent structure (e.g., house)

USE FOR: **Building**

Cooking

SN: The act of preparing foods for consumption

Crafting

SN: The process of creating useful items

Dating

SN: The process of getting to know and assessing one's romantic interest

Exploration

SN: Relating to the discovery of new places

Farming

SN: The act of raising animals or preparing/harvesting crops

RT: **Farm Animals**

Hacking

SN: Relating to the act of circumventing security measures in computerized systems for personal gain or social activism

Management

SN: The delegation of work among people, or the ability to prioritize tasks and carry them out to completion

Mining

SN: The process or business of digging in mines to obtain minerals, metals, jewels, etc.

Simulation

SN: A computerized imitation of real-world practices or occurrences

Sports

SN: An organized activity that involves multiple teams or individuals competing against each other to see who's the best

NT: **American Football, Baseball, Basketball, Bicycling, Billards, Bowling, Boxing, Cricket, Curling, Dance, Fencing, Fishing, Football, Golf, Hockey, Hunting, Martial Arts, Racing, Rugby, Sailing, Skateboarding, Skiing, Snowboarding, Surfing, Swimming, Table Tennis, Tennis, Volleyball, Wrestling**

American Football

SN: An organized sport played between two teams on a large field, involving the use of a football

BT: **Sports**

Baseball

SN: A game played on a large field between two teams, involving the use of bats, mitts, and a baseball

BT: **Sports**

Basketball

SN: A game played on a court with two hoops; the main objective of the game is to score the most points by shooting a basketball through the proper hoop

BT: **Sports**

Bicycling

SN: Riding one's bike through a set course

BT: **Sports**

Billiards

SN: A game that involves the use of a pool table, pool cues, a cue ball, and billiard balls; the object of the game is to sink the billiard balls into the pool table pockets in a predefined manner

USE FOR: **Pool**

BT: **Sports**

Bowling

SN: A game that relies on the use of bowling balls and bowling pins; the object of the game is to gain the highest score possible by knocking down the most pins in the least number of tries possible

BT: **Sports**

Boxing

SN: The sport centered on fighting others in a regulated, organized manner; it is often in a boxing ring, using boxing gloves and appropriate safety gear

BT: **Sports**

Cricket

SN: A game played with a ball and bat by two sides of usually 11 players each on a large field centering upon two wickets each defended by a batsman

BT: **Sports**

Curling

SN: A game in which two teams of four players slide special stones over ice toward a circle

BT: **Sports**

Dance

SN: A sport or activity that involves the graceful movement of one's body often in time

BT: **Sports**

Fencing

SN: A sport centered on the use of swords and graceful swordplay

BT: **Sports**

Fishing

SN: The sport or activity centered on being able to catch fish using a net or fishing pole

BT: **Sports**

Football

SN: A game played on a large field involving the use of a soccer ball and trying to score as many goals as possible

USE FOR: **Soccer**

BT: **Sports**

Golf

SN: A game in which individuals hit golf balls towards golf holes; the goal of the game is to do so in as few hits as possible

BT: **Sports**

Hockey

SN: A game that takes place in an ice rink where players must skate on ice and score as many goals as possible with a hockey puck using a hockey stick

BT: **Sports**

Hunting

SN: The activity of killing animals for sport, often in a regulated manner

BT: **Sports**

Martial Arts

SN: A type of combative art form with traditional roots

BT: **Sports**

Pool

USE: **Billards**

Racing

SN: A competition centered on who can travel through a set course the quickest

BT: **Sports**

Rugby

SN: A game played by two teams in which each team tries to carry or kick a ball over the other team's goal line

BT: **Sports**

Sailing

SN: The sport or activity of traveling on water in a sailboat

BT: **Sports**

Skateboarding

SN: A sport or activity centered on the use of skateboards and doing tricks

BT: **Sports**

Skiing

SN: A sport that involves the use of ski poles and ski boards to race down a snowy mountainside

BT: **Sports**

Snowboarding

SN: A sport that involves the use of snowboards to race down a snowy mountainside
BT: **Sports**

Surfing

SN: A sport or activity centered on the use of a surfboard, in which individuals ride atop waves
BT: **Sports**

Swimming

SN: The competitive sport that involves racing against others in a swimming pool to see who can swim the fastest
BT: **Sports**

Table Tennis

SN: Also known as ping pong, table tennis is a game played using a table divided with a low net, paddles, and a ping pong ball
BT: **Sports**

Tennis

SN: A game that takes place on a court separated by a low net, involving the use of tennis balls and tennis rackets
BT: **Sports**

Volleyball

SN: A game played with a volleyball on a large court, separated by a high net
BT: **Sports**

Wrestling

SN: A type of combative sport in which players must pin down others for a set period of time
BT: **Sports**

Trading

SN: The act of swapping items with others in exchange for different items

Travel

SN: The act of going on a trip or journey away from one's home

Types of Entities: Domain

Agriculture

SN: Relating to, caring for, or harvesting animals and crops
RT: **Farming, Farm Animals**

Architecture

SN: Relating to the design and construction of buildings

Art

SN: Relating to creative works
RT: **Music**

Astronomy

USE: **Space**

Business

SN: Relating to buying and selling of goods

Exercise

USE: **Health**

Fashion and Beauty

SN: Relating to the industry centered on clothing and outward appearances

Fitness

USE: **Health**

Health

SN: Relating to maintaining the physical condition of one's body

USE FOR: **Exercise, Fitness**

Music

SN: Relating to creative aural works

RT: **Art**

Mythology

SN: Relating to the study of myths and mythical beings like gods and goddesses

Science

SN: Relating to the study of the natural world

Space

SN: Relating to the solar system, and the infinite universes beyond/within it

USE FOR: **Astronomy**